Friends of the Mihai Eminescu Trust

Newsletter

2018 - 2019

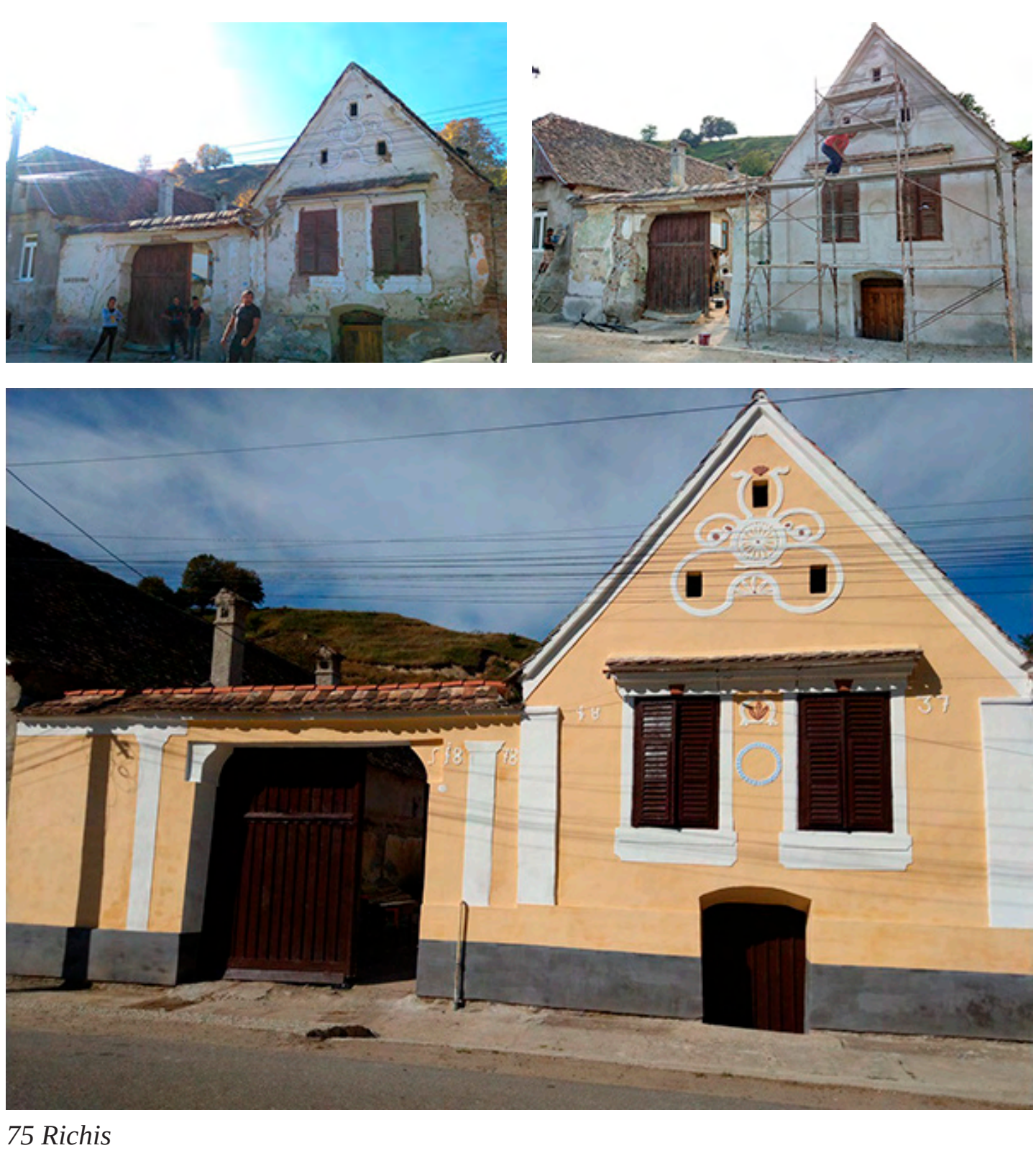
ANOTHER SUCCESSFUL YEAR

A year in which we have continued our work in the villages, restoring houses, planting trees, setting up workshops and educational projects, running guesthouses and business enterprises.

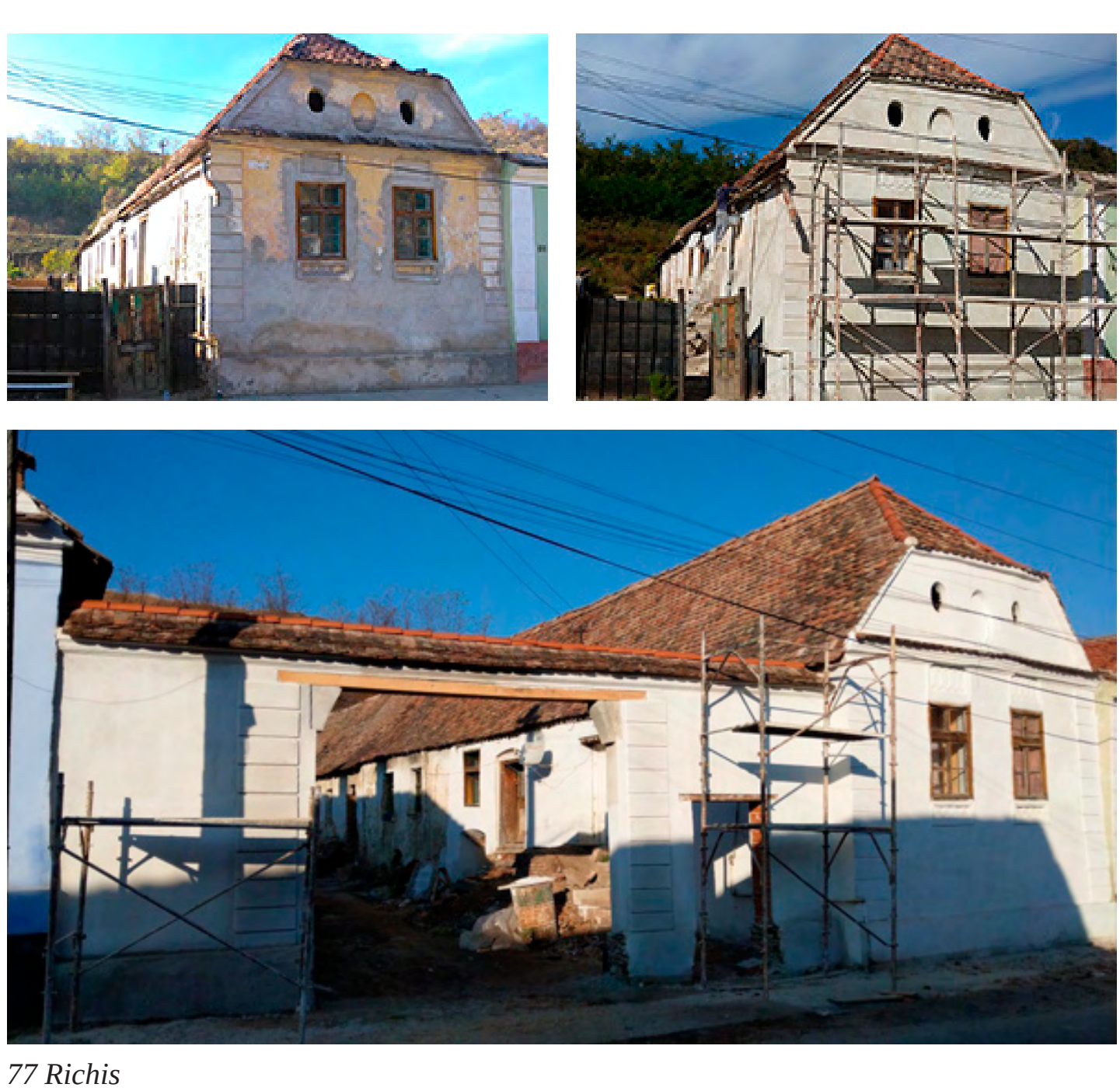
None of it would have been possible without our dedicated team in Sighisoara, Angela Mathe, Alexandru Neagu, and Michaela Türk as well as our builders and craftsmen. Our greatest debt is to our Romanian director Caroline Fernolend, whose leadership continues to provide the driving force behind our work in Transylvania.

BUILDINGS RESTORATION AND UPGRADES

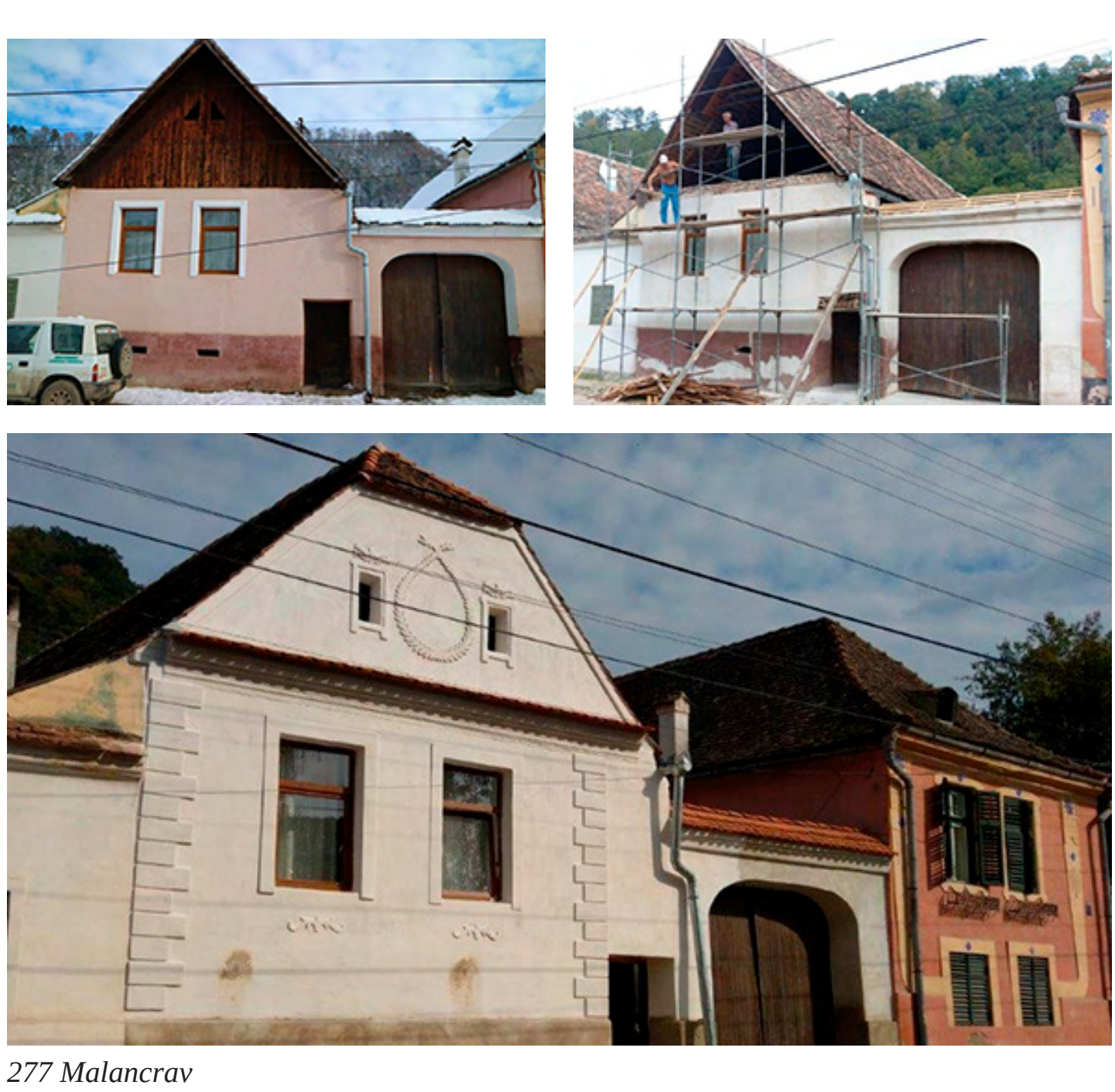
The restoration of 6 village houses was finished during the warm season between April and late September and work is in progress on a further 5 houses. Below are 3 examples. As usual the owners have contributed what they can towards the work.



75 Richis



77 Richis



277 Malancrav

We hope that the routine maintenance of roofs, courtyards, wells, barns, windows, gates, fences, interior and exterior lime wash and much more besides, will now be carried out regularly by the owners.

For the year ahead, the Trustees would be grateful for any help towards special houses which we will recommend and which are in greatest need of saving. In gratitude we would love to help arrange a visit to Saxon Transylvania for a Friend to choose one of the houses from the list we will provide.

VILLAGE PROJECTS

The MET has led 9 village community projects in Archita, Alma Vii, Viscri, Mâlâncrav, Biertan and Richis, as well as in the town of Sighișoara. All are aimed at reinforcing Transylvania's traditional culture, conserving its natural heritage and developing the growing demand for cultural tourism. Besides the restoration of buildings, also given help are language courses, creative workshops, training in entrepreneurship and the presentation of handcrafted products are given help. Individuals are encouraged to take part in developing the economy of their villages, setting up their own businesses and receive guidance in building professional careers.

ANTHONY GOODE

who died 19th Oct 2018

Anthony was one of the key experts who came unpaid to help us very early on to save some of the 250 deserted, decaying, beautiful 17th and 18th century farm houses in Saxon Transylvania. Under his guidance, the villagers learnt again their lost skills and set up small independent businesses. Anthony, like us, believed in all the S.P.A.B tenets of restoration - so important after 50 years of Ceausescu's love affair with concrete. He set about teaching best practice and restoration techniques to our small teams working on some of our most spectacular derelict houses, with amazing results: the Apafi Manor was one. Another was the Leather Makers Tower in Sighisoara's medieval fortified citadel, on its crumbling facade he uncovered the 12th -15th century battle scars inflicted by countless attacks from the Turks. He opened up the scars, and guided a team to repair them, using charcoal dust from the local charcoal burners, sand from the hillsides and hand-made Lime mortar from the restored village pits.

On behalf of the villagers and the Trustees, we pay tribute to Anthony's warmth and humour, his knowledge, dedication and patient understanding. We miss him very, very much.

SHROPSHIRE CONSERVATION TEAM

During 2018 the Shropshire team of conservation professionals led by Colin Richards have been refurbishing the house they bought in Stejareni village close to Sighisoara.

The house in Stejareni

The property is set in a beautiful wooded garden on the edge of the village adjacent to the old corn mill. It has an orchard, vineyard and small barn attached. In 2019 it will be available to rent by visitors. Later in the summer Colin and his team moved on to restore a Saxon barn in Archita. The trainee builders learnt new skills in stone masonry, carpentry and working with lime.

Colin Richards (3rd from left) and the team.

Colin continues to promote the work of the MET in his conservation lectures as far afield as China, Poland and Slovenia.

LONDON SCHOOLS SYMPHONY ORCHESTRA IN TRANSYLVANIA

After sell-out performances in the cities of Sibiu and Brasov, on 31st July the LSSO orchestra travelled to Mălâncrav. In the heart of Transylvania, this is the village where the Trust has saved and restored many farm houses and smaller buildings, as well as the 18th century Hungarian church and the 17th century Apafi Manor.

Some of the orchestra arriving at the Apafi Manor

The hundred strong group of young players was led by their conductor Peter Ash. They spent a day working and playing with village dancers and musicians who were under the guidance of Andrea Rost from the MET. In the words of the orchestra's tour leader, "..there, among horses, carts, milkmaids and men mowing the grass with scythes, our metropolitan kids ate, drank, made music and danced with local children and young adults".

The musicians relaxing in front of the Manor before their evening performance.

In the evening at the Apafi Manor, the orchestra performed Faure's *Pelleas et Melisande*, Debussy's *Premiere Rhapsodie* and an arrangement of Traditional Saxon Dance Music.

On September 17th, following the success of their Romania Tour, the orchestra gave a concert at the Barbican Centre in London. Before it began the Trust invited MET Friends to a drink in the Fountain Room, where they were able to meet the conductor Peter Ash and some of the players. The programme for the evening centred on works inspired by Romanian and Hungarian folk music. The programme included Enescu's *Romanian Rhapsody No 1*, Schumann's *Piano Concerto* (soloist Aleksandar Madzar) and ended with a stunning performance of Bartók's *Concerto for Orchestra*.

Peter Ash, Artistic Director & Conductor of the London Schools Symphony Orchestra

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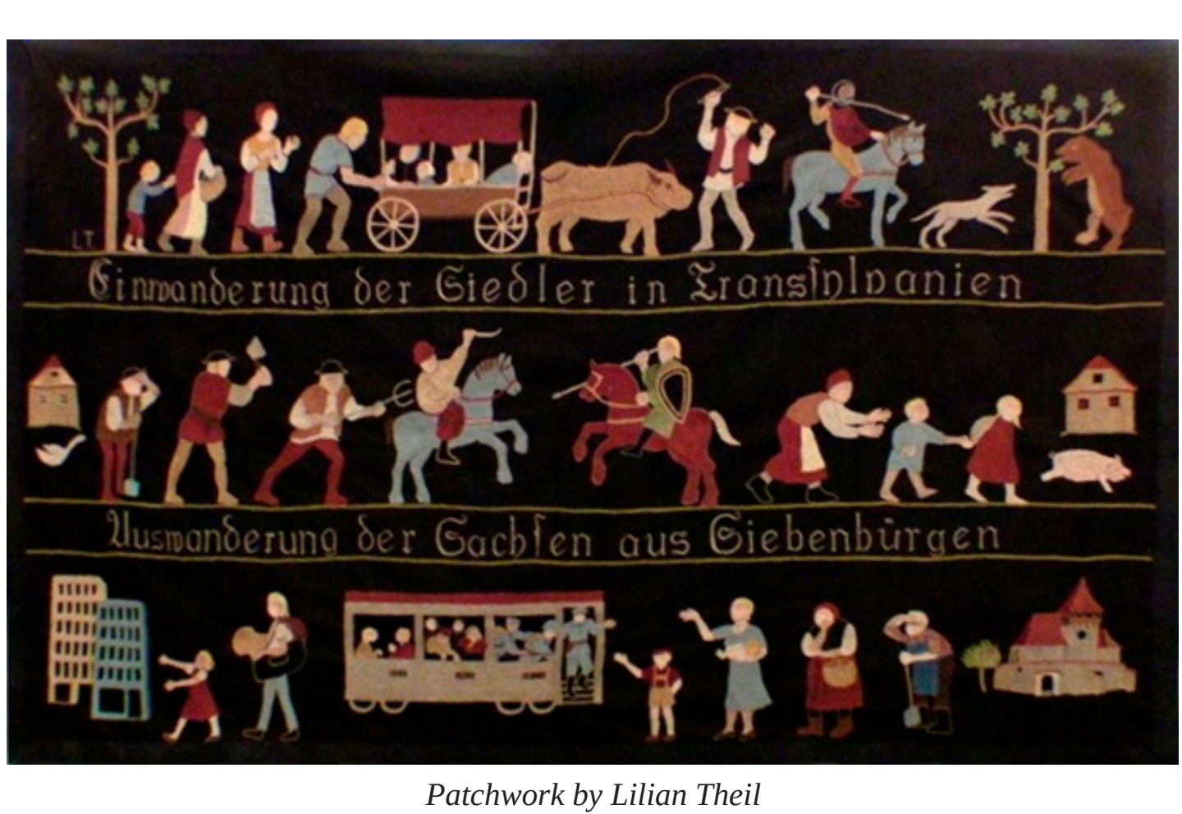
RICHIS LITERARY FESTIVAL

Richis Village (Photo: Jamie Gould)

Once again MET was pleased to be supporting the Book Festival in Richis, which began on 13th September.

Philip Mansell

Amongst the speakers in this year's programme was Dr. Philip Mansel, historian of France and of the Ottoman Empire. his talk to the festival audience was on 'The Sun King and the Prince of Transylvania: Louis XIV and Ferenc II Rákóczi'


Einwanderung der Siedler in Tranſylvanien
Auswanderung der Sachſen aus Siebenbürgen

Patchwork by Lilian Theil

Another, sponsored by the MET, was the Saxon artist Lilian Theil in conversation with author Andrea Rost, talking about Theil's work and her life in Saxon Transylvania. Her patchwork textiles are beautiful and political and unique. Now in her eighties, she lives in Sighisoara.

For some of the guests, the MET provided the beautiful, newly restored Richis house in the heart of the village. Details of MET guesthouses can be found on the Experience Transylvania website.

RICHIS

The restored house, No. 119 Richis, is now available as one of the Trust's many guesthouses.

Inside the restored house, the library, kitchen and a top floor bedroom

For booking information for all MET guesthouses, see: Experience Transylvania

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MET and ACCOR

Planting for the Planet Programme

Between 15th March and 30th May 2018, **135,425** trees were planted in 10 village locations, covering a total area of 32 hectares. Over 8,000 volunteers, many of them school children, took part in the programme, restoring degraded natural ecosystems and at the same time raising awareness of important environmental issues. Since the joint **MET/ACCOR** project began in 2009, the total number of trees planted stands at well over 2 million.

Varieties of trees planted this year included: *Fagus* (Beech), *Picea abies* (Spruce), *Fraxinus* (Ash), *Quercus petrae* (Evergreen oak), *Acer pseudoplatanus* (Sycamore maple), *Larix*, *Alnus glutinosa* (Common alder).

AWARDS & NETWORKS

MET received 2nd prize from the *European Garden Award* in the category of the **'Best Development of a Cultural Landscape of European Relevance'**. The Trust was also included in the Europa Nostra Learning Kit: Citizen Engagement & Education, aimed at providing CSOs with a better understanding of citizen engagement and education in heritage. MET is one of the Faro Convention Network Active Members.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The projects described above are only a selection of the highlights from projects completed during 2018.

The Horizon Foundation provided funding and sponsorship for which we are most grateful. Also to Jon Moynihan, Richard Cundall, David Campbell, Christopher and Primrose Arnander, Belinda Cadbury, Peter Ash, Roy Foster, and John Murray and many wonderful people who have contributed their work free.

Partners: Horizon Foundation, Accor-Orbis Hotels, Keep Giving Foundation, Cory and Amy Reid, Markus Schmitz, Humedica e.V., Wirtschaftskammer Lichtenstein, Asociația de Dezvoltare Intercomunitară Țara Făgărașuui, Federația TransylvaNET, Südtiroler Schützenbund, Leuphana University Lüneburg, AFCN - National Cultural Fund Administration, Faro Network, Council of Europe.

We thank all those who joined Friends of the MET, and our thanks for all their generous donations.

FUNDING

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any offerings to our mailing address below. Over its first 12 years the MET benefited from the remarkable generosity of the Packard Humanities Institute. Their programme of giving came to a conclusion five years ago so, in order to continue with our restoration projects, we must look elsewhere for our funding, which makes every grant or donation all the more valuable. In 2018 our major new project will be the Alexander Franz house, in addition we'll be getting under way with another 8 important house restorations.

Our mailing address is:
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